Ask First, Then Listen

The first conversation with your wife about what she'd want to keep.

You've had thousands of conversations with your wife. This is one you haven't found the first sentence for, partly because nothing is wrong and you don't want it to sound as though something is.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: hear what she'd want to keep, and write it down the way she said it. It isn't for planning anything, and it can stop whenever she'd like it to.

Who should be there

The two of you, the first time. What the kids hope for is a separate conversation, later, and how much they hear of this one is hers to say.

Pick somewhere ordinary. The Conversation Project's starter guide suggests places like the kitchen table, the car, or a walk. [1]

Leave the notebook in the drawer. Write it down afterward, the same day if you can.

How to open

Ask whether she'd like to have the conversation before you ask anything else. Care teams are encouraged to begin the same way: by asking the person if they'd like to talk about what matters to them, and how involved they want others to be. [2]

It can help to say something of your own, too. The National Institute on Aging notes that a person may feel more comfortable talking about their preferences if you talk about what matters to you as well. [3]

- “I've been thinking about the years ahead, and I realized I've never asked what you'd want. Could we talk about it sometime? It doesn't have to be today.”
- “Nothing's wrong, and I'm not planning anything. I'd just like to know what matters most to you, so I'm not guessing.”
- If she says “not today,” take that as her answer and thank her. The subject can wait until she brings it up or you ask again.
- Say what the conversation is for: hearing what she'd want to keep. Say what it isn't for: deciding anything, or changing anything about how the two of you live now.

Questions to ask

Ask her

Start with everyday life. You don't need all five; two good answers are a conversation.

1. What does a good day look like for you?

2. Which parts of your week would you hate to give up?

3. What have you always done your own way, and want to go on doing your own way?

4. If things changed someday, what would you most want to stay the same?

5. Is there anything about the future you'd rather not talk about yet?

Ask before you finish

1. Would you like to come back to this, and who would you want to be part of it next time?

Ask the kids, separately and later

A different conversation, on a different day. Their hopes go on the page beside hers, not in place of them.

1. What do you hope for her in the years ahead, and what concerns you?

2. If she ever needed more help, what could you honestly offer, and what couldn't you?

How to write down what was said

Keep her words apart from everyone else's, yours included, and use quotation marks only where you remember the wording. Where someone in the family hopes for something different from what she said, write both and don't settle it.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	WHEN	DIFFERENT FROM WHAT SOMEONE ELSE SAID?
“My own kitchen, and bridge on Thursdays.”	She did	Sunday, over coffee	
Would like the whole family to sit down together soon.	Our son	Tuesday, by phone	She said she'd rather talk with me first

What not to decide yet

She is well, and nothing needs settling. Leave all of these open, however the conversation goes.

- Where anyone will live.
- Whether she needs help of any kind.
- Who would do what if she ever did.
- Whose wish comes first when two people want different things.

What you can agree on today

- That you'll write down what she said and show it to her.
- Who she's comfortable with you talking to next.
- How you'll come back to it: a date, an occasion, or simply “when one of us asks.”

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a difference between what she wants and what someone else hopes for, and it doesn't tell you what a professional would say. It gets her words onto a page, with the open questions left on it.

Ready for the next step?

You found a first sentence, asked, listened, and wrote down what she said. The care interview carries that further: it goes through your wife's situation area by area, so her wishes sit beside a full account of how she lives now, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The good-day question is one The Conversation Project's starter guide asks; the other questions are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement), Your Conversation Starter Guide: How to talk about what matters to you and have a say in your health care
2. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults
3. National Institute on Aging, Advance Care Planning and Health Care Decisions: Tips for Caregivers and Families

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